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WHEN BELIEF MET REALITY DOWN UNDER

The latest Ashes series **exposed** the limitations of Bazball as Australia outplayed England with grit and guile.

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England arrived in Australia with reasons to believe this Ashes might bend differently. Under Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum, it had won the first Test of all five Bazball tours before this. It was also presented, unusually, with an Australian attack that looked compromised before the series began. Pat Cummins was expected to play just one Test. Josh Hazlewood was ruled out altogether. Nathan Lyon's involvement would be limited. **Had England been offered that scenario in advance, it would have taken it without hesitation and perhaps imagined an opening.**

Instead, it left Australia having lost 4-1, its campaign ending with a five-wicket defeat in Sydney that merely confirmed what had been clear long before. The solitary victory, a two-day shootout on a grassy Melbourne pitch, stood apart from the rest of the series, an outlier rather than a corrective.

While Australia adapted quickly to its reduced resources and found authority elsewhere, England failed to exploit the absences in front of it. The series was decided not by what the host lacked, but by what it still possessed and deployed with certainty.

That is where Mitchell Starc (left) came to define the Ashes. Not as a convenient stand-in for missing stars, but as the enforcer of a structure England could neither destabilise nor escape. He struck early, sustained pressure, and ensured England was constantly reacting rather than shaping contests.

Starc set the tone immediately. His wicket in the first over in Perth denied England the one luxury touring sides crave in Australia: time.